The ‘damaging evidence’ alluded to the Tata team having had the knowledge of Gogoi’s whereabouts in September. The imputation was that the Tata management was aware that he was in India on 15 September, when Ratan and Krishna Kumar had met Mahanta. The group, on its part, countered the leak, stating that it was being targeted.

To explain his position, Ratan got veteran criminal lawyer Ram Jethmalani, who was also the Tata Group’s lawyer, to write to the Assam chief minister, giving the Tatas’ version of the story. Jethmalani wrote: ‘They [R.K. Krishna Kumar and Chairman Ratan Tata] made no false statement to you. They stated what they honestly believed at that time. It is their subsequent discovery that Dr Gogoi was already in India and had used their guest house which he was entitled to do without reporting to anyone … Even if they had some inkling they would not dare contradict your Chief Secretary who affirmed that he was in the US [and that] Interpol was after him and he would be arrested the moment he lands in India.’

In addition, Ratan went to the press to explain his position. In an interview, he said: ‘The Assam Government and sections of the press have prejudged Tata Tea to be guilty even before it has been heard … I don’t know if we are being wilfully targeted. But we are certainly being treated in a manner which is not fair and just. Tata Tea has done nothing wrong and, certainly, nothing that is anti-national.’

He elaborated on the foundational philosophy of the group and how sponsoring of social welfare programmes is a core corporate goal: ‘Tata Tea has not undertaken welfare activities in Assam only to appease any segment of the population. It has far more intensive schemes in south India, which does not suffer from this problem [terrorism]. It [Tata Tea] has endeavoured to be a good corporate citizen. And whatever the company has done, it has done to protect its own people.’

Ratan further lamented that the group was being unfairly targeted: ‘From everything one hears, many companies have been paying money to the extremists. Tata Tea has not. Tata Tea made counter-proposals of putting investments into Assam and, in this particular case, extended facilities in terms of medical treatment through payments directly to hospitals—not to individuals and not to associations. I don’t understand why Tata Tea is being picked upon. In fact, we should be applauded for what we have done. … The way this entire matter is being projected, I cannot help but feel there is an underlying objective to besmirch the reputation of Tatas.’